

Trojan in a PDF

A new Mac vulnerability Trojan disguises itself as a PDF file to fool users into downloading and opening it which installs an Apache server on your Mac

Avast to secure cellphones

Avast has acquired mobile security company ITAgents which makes security app for Android and Symbian phones

Adobe under attack?

Adobe software's popularity and wide usage make it a prime target for cyber criminals, ahead of even Microsoft software, if you can believe that!

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McAfee Labs recently published its Q2 2011 Threat Report, in which the security research firm claims to have picked up a pretty large number of exploits that malware authors have written in an effort to target vulnerabilities in Adobe software. The number of Adobe exploits discovered in June 2011 alone, upwards of 14,000, dwarfs the sub-1000 exploits in the same period that were targeting Microsoft software. McAfee is quick to point out, however, that this vast difference in numbers doesn't prove Adobe's products are in any way more vulnerable or buggy than Microsoft's, just that they're drawing cybercriminal attention because of its popularity and wide usage. Adobe's products include — but are not limited to — Photoshop, Premier Pro, Flash, Acrobat, Audition, Dreamweaver, Illustrator and InDesign.

The report also emphasised the steady rise of malware, not just in the past six months, but in the past eighteen. McAfee Labs claims to have identified over six million unique samples in Q2 2011, taking the total number to over 65 million samples, a 22 per cent increase over 2010's numbers. According to McAfee, "researchers estimate that this 'Malware Zoo' will reach at least 75 million sam-

ples by the year's end." Out of this, the most interesting — or alarming, depending on the way you look at it — development was the rise of fake anti-virus software for Macintosh. McAfee goes on to say it's now only a matter of time before malware makes it onto iOS, adding that it's probably a case of "when" rather than "if". So if you use an Apple product, you'd best not get complacent.

Rootkits and stealth-based malware, which operate as code that hide elements from the operating system and thus make other malware more dangerous, have also seen a dramatic rise — 38 per cent over 2010 to be precise. The first half of 2011 was the busiest six months in their existence.

On the other side of the pond, Android has grown 76 per cent to become the Mobile OS most targeted by malware in Q2. Such is the popularity of Android among malware

devs, that the amount of new malware for the OS in Q2 outnumbered those for the next most targeted OS, Java Micro Edition, by three times. "While Symbian OS and Java ME remain the most targeted to date, the rapid rise in Android malware in Q2 indicates that the platform could become an increasing target for cybercriminals — affecting everything from calendar apps, to comedy apps to SMS messages," said McAfee.

Malware for Android take advantage of exploits, employ Botnet functionality and use rootkit features for stealth, much like their PC counterparts. The report says the malware infect Android devices using several means, one of which is by corrupting legit apps. For example, there was one which disguised itself as an update to Angry Birds! Once installed, Android malware proceed to send text messages to your contacts - or to premium rate

numbers - sign you up for premium subscriptions and send sensitive information to the attacker.

Web threats included the discovery of around 7,300 new web sites per day with bad or malicious reputations, along with 3,000 new web sites per day that delivered malware or potentially unwanted programs (PUPs). Phishing web sites weren't too far behind, with around 2,700 new URLs discovered per day.

The report says the downturn of spam messages has stalled in Q2, but in terms of volume and not effectiveness, which has actually gone up. McAfee says though, that it expects a sharp rise in the number of spam messages (and botnet activity) soon, as the current measures start to wear off. While India isn't at the very top in terms of spam volume, it's still quite close to it with nearly a hundred million being recorded in Q2.

Of course, the report includes details of activities of hacktivist groups like Anonymous and LulzSec, as well as cases of "cyberwar" recorded during the quarter. These include the attacks on European Commission, US and European space agencies, the Oak Ridge National Laboratory and the Norwegian military. Around 20 global attacks were reported in Q2, with a majority of them allegedly at the hands of LulzSec.

Visit <http://bit.ly/pTnPal> for the complete McAfee Labs Q2 2011 threat report. 

